

Cox 1987 Claude Guide

Cox, Gary W. *The Efficient Secret: The Cabinet and the Development of Political Parties in Victorian England.*

Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987.

Contents

1	Central Claims	2
2	Periodization: Unreformed vs. Reformed Parliament	2
3	The Electoral Connection Mechanism	3
4	Institutional and Procedural Change in the Commons	4
5	Core Works Cited	5
6	Methodological Contributions and Limitations	5
7	Connections to the Broader Literature	6

1 Central Claims

- The title borrows Walter Bagehot’s phrase from *The English Constitution* (1867): the “efficient secret” of British government is the close fusion of executive and legislative power in the **cabinet**, which sits inside Parliament rather than separate from it. Cox’s book asks how and why that fusion became so tight, disciplined, and stable over the nineteenth century.
- **Core puzzle:** the early-nineteenth-century (“unreformed”) House of Commons was a candidate-centered, faction-ridden, patronage-driven body in which individual MPs had substantial independence. By the late nineteenth century, Britain had cohesive, disciplined, programmatic parties and a cabinet with sweeping control over the parliamentary agenda. What explains this transformation?
- **Central argument:** the expansion of the electoral franchise (Reform Acts of 1832, 1867, and 1884) is the underlying driver. As the electorate grew from a small, personally-known set of local notables into a mass electorate, voters increasingly could not monitor or evaluate individual MPs’ behavior directly. Instead, they came to evaluate **parties as collective teams**, rewarding or punishing the governing party’s overall record. This made a party’s collective reputation—its “brand”—electorally decisive.
- Once collective reputation became the currency of electoral competition, individual MPs had a rational incentive to **cede power to party leaders and whips** and to support strong internal party discipline and a cabinet with real agenda-control authority, because a well-managed, coherent legislative program benefited the whole party’s brand (and hence every individual MP’s reelection prospects) more than any MP’s personal, particularistic dealings could.
- This is fundamentally an **electoral-connection argument** (in the spirit of Mayhew’s work on the U.S. Congress) applied to explain institutional and procedural change: electoral incentives, not exogenous ideology or class conflict alone, drove MPs to build the institutions of cabinet government and party discipline.
- The transformation is simultaneously electoral (change in who votes and how they evaluate politicians) and procedural (change in House of Commons rules governing the agenda, obstruction, and the Speaker’s powers)—Cox insists these two levels of change are tightly linked, not coincidental.

2 Periodization: Unreformed vs. Reformed Parliament

- **The unreformed system (pre-1832):** a small, restricted electorate (often a few hundred voters per constituency, many controlled by a local patron or “pocket borough”); MPs won and held seats through personal followings, patronage networks, bribery, and local deals rather than national party platforms. Government was formed and sustained through shifting personal/factional coalitions, not disciplined party majorities.

- **Weak party cohesion pre-reform:** votes in the Commons did not reliably track party lines; ministries could be brought down by shifting, ad hoc combinations of factions; MPs' loyalty was to patrons, local interests, and personal advancement more than to a party program.
- **The Reform Act of 1832:** expanded the franchise moderately and rationalized constituency boundaries, beginning the erosion of the pure patronage system, but the electorate remained relatively small and local ties still mattered enormously.
- **The Reform Act of 1867:** a much larger expansion of the franchise (extending the vote to much of the urban male working class), decisively shifting the scale of the electorate and making personal, face-to-face campaigning and patronage-based control increasingly infeasible.
- **The Reform Act of 1884:** extended household suffrage to the counties, further nationalizing and mass-ifying the electorate.
- **The reformed system (by the late nineteenth century):** mass electorates evaluate competing parties on their governing record and platform; elections function increasingly as a national choice of *government* rather than a local choice of *representative*; party organizations (caucuses, whips, central party machinery) develop to coordinate campaigns and enforce voting discipline in the Commons.

3 The Electoral Connection Mechanism

- **Information and monitoring costs:** in a small electorate, voters can plausibly know an individual MP's personal record, character, and services rendered. In a mass electorate, this kind of fine-grained monitoring is prohibitively costly for most voters, who instead rely on cheap, general cues—above all, the reputation of the party label.
- **The party as an electoral team:** once the party label becomes the primary cue voters use, an MP's individual electoral fate is bundled with the fate of the party as a whole. This creates a strong **collective-action incentive**: every MP benefits when the party as a whole governs competently and delivers a program voters approve of, and every MP is harmed when the party's record is muddled, incoherent, or embarrassing.
- **Rational cession of power:** because individual MPs cannot unilaterally produce a coherent, attractive party record, but a disciplined party *can*, MPs have a self-interested reason to support institutions—whips, caucuses, cabinet agenda control—that let party leaders coordinate a coherent collective program, even though this means individual MPs sacrifice autonomy.
- **Solving a collective-action problem:** this is structurally similar to Olson's (1965) logic—individually rational behavior (each MP pursuing personal/local advantage) undersupplies the collective good (a strong, coherent party brand) unless some mechanism

(party discipline, whipping, agenda control) solves the free-rider problem. Cox effectively shows the British Parliament “solving” an Olsonian collective-action problem through institutional innovation driven by electoral incentive.

- **Reputation as an asset:** party reputation functions like a valuable, quasi-public good internal to the party—costly to build, easily damaged by ill-disciplined or contradictory behavior from individual members, and hence worth protecting through internal enforcement mechanisms (whips, sanctions for rebellion, leadership control over nominations and honors).

4 Institutional and Procedural Change in the Commons

- **Growth of government control over the parliamentary timetable:** over the nineteenth century, government business increasingly crowded out private members’ business, giving the cabinet effective control over what Parliament debates and when.
- **Rise of the whip system:** formalized party whips emerge as an institution for monitoring, communicating, and enforcing voting discipline among MPs—the organizational infrastructure making collective party reputation actually deliverable.
- **Procedural tools against obstruction:** as party competition intensified (and as Irish Nationalist MPs in particular used procedural obstruction as a tactic), the Commons developed new rules—closure motions (ending debate by majority vote) and later the “guillotine” (allocating fixed time to each stage of a bill)—that shifted procedural power toward the government and away from individual backbenchers or minorities.
- **Strengthening of the Speaker’s authority:** procedural reforms enhanced the Speaker’s power to control debate, select amendments, and manage obstruction, complementing the shift toward disciplined, government-controlled proceedings.
- **Cabinet agenda power:** by the end of the period Cox studies, the cabinet has become the effective agenda-setter for the House of Commons, able to determine what legislation is considered and largely assured of disciplined party support for passing its program—the institutional endpoint of “cabinet government.”
- **Emergence of the party manifesto and “mandate” politics:** general elections increasingly function as a contest between rival party programs, with the winning party claiming an electoral mandate to enact its platform—turning Parliament into the vehicle for delivering promised collective goods rather than a forum for individual constituency bargaining.

5 Core Works Cited

- **Walter Bagehot**, *The English Constitution* (1867)—the direct source of Cox’s title and organizing concept; Bagehot’s original description of cabinet government as the “efficient secret” fusing executive and legislative power.
- **David Mayhew**, *Congress: The Electoral Connection* (1974)—the foundational statement of the electoral-connection logic (legislators as single-minded seekers of reelection) that Cox adapts and extends to explain party-level, rather than purely individual-level, institutional development in a parliamentary (not presidential) system.
- **Samuel Beer**, *Modern British Politics* (1965)—a major prior account of the development of British party government and mass party organization that Cox engages and revises with a more explicitly electoral-institutionalist mechanism.
- **Mancur Olson**, *The Logic of Collective Action* (1965)—the collective-action logic underlying why disciplined party organization does not arise automatically from shared electoral interest and requires institutional solutions (whips, sanctions) to be sustained.
- **Maurice Duverger**, *Political Parties* (1951/1954)—background on party organization and discipline as a general comparative phenomenon; Cox’s account can be read as a detailed causal history of how one particular case of Duvergian party cohesion actually came about.
- **Cox’s own later work**, *Making Votes Count* (1997)—extends the electoral-connection logic from a single historical case (Britain) into a general comparative theory of how electoral rules shape strategic coordination among parties and voters; *The Efficient Secret* is in many ways the historical seedbed for that later comparative theory.

6 Methodological Contributions and Limitations

- **Historical institutionalism meets rational choice**: the book is a signature example of using rational-choice electoral logic to explain long-run institutional change, rather than treating institutions as exogenous or purely path-dependent/cultural artifacts.
- **Linking micro-incentives to macro-institutional outcomes**: Cox carefully connects a micro-level mechanism (individual MPs’ reelection incentives under changing electorates) to macro-level institutional outcomes (cabinet agenda power, party discipline, procedural reform)—a model of multi-level causal argument.
- **Endogeneity and reverse causation**: as with many historical-institutionalist accounts, it is difficult to fully rule out that procedural/party changes were driven by factors other than franchise expansion (e.g., ideological polarization, the rise of mass media, Irish Home Rule politics specifically driving obstruction-control reforms) rather than being a pure downstream consequence of the electoral connection.

- **Scope conditions:** the argument is built from a single, extended case (Britain), which raises questions about generalizability—though Cox’s later comparative work (1997) partially addresses this by extending similar electoral-connection logic across many electoral systems.
- **Data and evidence:** the book combines qualitative political history with quantitative evidence on procedural change (e.g., allocation of parliamentary time, roll-call cohesion), an early example of combining archival/historical and quantitative-institutional methods in the study of legislative development.

7 Connections to the Broader Literature

- **Cox 1997 (*Making Votes Count*):** the most direct connection in this reading list—1987 is the historical/electoral-connection microfoundation for the general comparative theory of strategic coordination developed a decade later. Read together, they show Cox moving from a single deep historical case to a general cross-national theory built on the same underlying logic (electoral incentives shape party-system outcomes).
- **Olson 1965:** party discipline is a solution to an Olsonian collective-action problem among MPs who individually might prefer more autonomy but collectively benefit from a coherent, disciplined party brand.
- **Huntington 1968:** Huntington’s concept of political institutionalization (rules and organizations gaining autonomy, complexity, and coherence over time) closely parallels Cox’s account of the Commons developing autonomous, coherent procedural rules and party organizations out of what was previously a looser, more personalistic system.
- **Weber 1968 / Weber 2013:** the shift from patronage-based, personalistic parliamentary politics to disciplined, rule-bound cabinet government mirrors Weber’s ideal-typical shift from traditional/patrimonial authority toward legal-rational, bureaucratized authority—party discipline and procedural rules are a Weberian “routinization” of what had been more personalistic political relationships.
- **Lipset and Rokkan 1967:** Lipset and Rokkan’s “freezing” thesis describes European party systems stabilizing around social cleavages by the 1920s; Cox’s book is in effect a detailed causal account of the antecedent institutional process—the development of disciplined, brand-based parties—that made cleavage-based party systems possible to freeze into place in Britain specifically.
- **Huber and Shipan 2002:** both books examine how electoral/political incentives shape the design of formal institutional discretion (legislative-executive relations, delegation, and agenda control), though Huber and Shipan focus on statutory delegation to bureaucracies in modern democracies while Cox focuses on the historical construction of cabinet agenda power itself.

- **Moore 1966:** both address the transformation of political order accompanying the expansion of political participation beyond a narrow landed/patronage elite, though Moore emphasizes class coalitions and violent ruptures while Cox emphasizes gradual electoral-institutional adaptation within a relatively continuous constitutional framework—a useful contrast in modes of political development.
- **Powell 2000:** Powell’s comparative work on how electoral rules shape the “chain of responsiveness” between voters and governments builds on exactly the kind of mandate/accountability politics that Cox shows emerging historically in Britain as cabinet government took shape.